

Chapter 34 — Hithpael Semantic Function Sorting

BBH Chapter 34 · Hithpael Strong Verbs

Classify each Hithpael verb as IR (Intensive-Reflexive), RC (Reciprocal), IT (Iterative), or SA (Simple Action) — the four Hithpael functions from §34.2. Answer key is on the last page.

IR = Intensive-Reflexive (subject acts on itself) | RC = Reciprocal (subjects act on one another) | IT = Iterative (repeated or habitual action)
| SA = Simple Action (no reflexive/reciprocal/repetitive force — reads like a Qal)

#	Hebrew	Conjugation	Ref	Contextual Gloss	Function
1	מִתְהַלֵּךְ	Participle ms	Gen 3:8	"walking about (in the garden)"	
2	יִתְחַבֵּא	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 3:8	"he hid himself"	
3	יִתְהַלֵּךְ	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 5:22	"Enoch walked about (with God)"	
4	יִתְעַצֵּב	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 6:6	"he was grieved (to his heart)"	
5	יִתְגַּל	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 9:21	"he uncovered himself"	
6	הִתְהַלֵּךְ	Imperative 2ms	Gen 13:17	"walk about (through the land)!"	
7	הִתְעַנֵּי	Imperative 2fs	Gen 16:9	"humble yourself!"	
8	הִתְהַלֵּךְ	Imperative 2ms	Gen 17:1	"walk about before me!"	
9	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 18:2	"he prostrated himself"	
10	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 19:1	"Lot bowed down"	
11	יִתְפַּלֵּל	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 20:17	"he prayed"	
12	הִתְבָּרְכוּ	Weqatal 3cp	Gen 22:18	"they will bless themselves / be blessed"	
13	הִתְהַלַּכְתִּי	Qatal 1cs	Gen 24:40	"I have walked about (before the LORD)"	
14	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 24:26	"he bowed down and worshiped"	
15	הִתְעַשְׂקוּ	Qatal 3cp	Gen 26:20	"they quarreled"	
16	מִתְנַחֵם	Participle ms	Gen 27:42	"is comforting himself"	
17	יִתְנַכְּלוּ	Wayyiqtol 3mp	Gen 37:18	"they plotted against him"	
18	יִתְאַבֵּל	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Gen 37:34	"he mourned"	
19	תִּתְכַּסֶּה	Wayyiqtol 3fs	Gen 24:65	"she covered herself"	
20	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Wayyiqtol 3mp	Gen 33:7	"they bowed down"	
21	אֶתְנַהֵּלָה	Cohortative 1cs	Gen 33:14	"I will journey on slowly"	
22	הִתְקַדְּשׁוּ	Imperative 2mp	Exo 19:22	"consecrate yourselves!"	
23	יִתְחַזַּק	Wayyiqtol 3ms	Exo 7:13	"and his heart was strengthened"	
24	יִתְהַלְּלוּ	Wayyiqtol 3mp	Ps 97:7	"they glory in idols"	
25	הִתְחַזַּק	Imperative 2mp	Jos 1:6	"be strong!"	

Reflection Questions

1. The Hithpael of הִלָּךְ appears five times (items 1, 3, 6, 8, 13). Why is this classified as Iterative rather than Intensive-Reflexive? What does the "walking about" context add that a single walk would not convey?
2. Item 12 (וּכְרַחֲבֵתָהּ, Gen 22:18): this form can be translated "bless themselves" (Intensive-Reflexive) or "be blessed" (passive-like). The same tension appears in Gen 12:3. What grammatical evidence in the verse helps decide which reading is better?
3. Items 15 (וַיִּקְדָּשׁוּ, quarreled) and 17 (וַיִּלְכְּדוּ, plotted): both involve conflict between parties. What makes one Reciprocal and the other Intensive-Reflexive rather than Reciprocal? Does the number of participants or the object of the action make the difference?
4. Items 23 and 25 both come from קָזַח, and item 24 from לָלַח. In what way does the Hithpael's reflexive coloring ("strengthen YOURSELF," "praise/exalt ONESELF") add nuance beyond a plain Qal or Piel for the same root?

Answer Key

#	Hebrew	Ref	Fn	Explanation
1	מִתְהַלֵּךְ	Gen 3:8	IT	Back-and-forth movement; not a single walk
2	יִתְחַבֵּא	Gen 3:8	IR	Subject acts on itself; concealment
3	יִתְהַלֵּךְ	Gen 5:22	IT	Habitual/continuous walking; same root as #1
4	יִתְעַצֵּב	Gen 6:6	IR	Inward grief; the LORD's heart acts on itself
5	יִתְגַּל	Gen 9:21	IR	Reflexive uncovering; subject = object
6	הִתְהַלֵּךְ	Gen 13:17	IT	Command to traverse repeatedly; same root
7	הִתְעַנִּי	Gen 16:9	IR	Reflexive self-humbling; subject acts on itself
8	הִתְהַלֵּךְ	Gen 17:1	IT	Continuous conduct before YHWH
9	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Gen 18:2	IR	Reflexive prostration; Ill-he Hithpael
10	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Gen 19:1	IR	Same form; Lot prostrates himself before the angels
11	יִתְפַּלֵּל	Gen 20:17	SA	BBH §34.2.4 own Simple Action example; "pray" has no separate reflexive or reciprocal
12	הִתְבָּרַךְ	Gen 22:18	IR	Reflexive blessing; can also be read as passive-like
13	הִתְהַלֵּכְתִּי	Gen 24:40	IT	Continuous habitual conduct
14	יִשְׁתַּחוּ	Gen 24:26	IR	Same form; servant prostrates himself
15	הִתְעַשְׂקוּ	Gen 26:20	RC	Mutual quarreling; the herdsmen act on one another
16	מִתְנַחֵם	Gen 27:42	IR	Esau comforting himself with the thought of revenge
17	יִתְנַגְּלוּ	Gen 37:18	IR	Brothers act collectively against Joseph — not mutual action on each other
18	יִתְאַבֵּל	Gen 37:34	IR	Inward grief expressed outwardly; reflexive mourning
19	תִּתְכַסֶּה	Gen 24:65	IR	Rebekah covered herself with her veil
20	יִשְׁתַּחֲוּוּ	Gen 33:7	IR	Jacob's wives and children prostrate themselves
21	אֶתְהַלֵּלָהּ	Gen 33:14	IT	Iterative/continuous slow travel; guiding the flocks
22	הִתְקַדְּשׁוּ	Exo 19:22	IR	The priests prepare themselves for the theophany
23	יִתְחַזַּק	Exo 7:13	IR	The heart strengthened itself / became stubborn
24	יִתְהַלֵּל	Ps 97:7	IR	Reflexive self-glorification; boasting in idols
25	הִתְחַזְּקוּ	Jos 1:6	IR	Command to strengthen themselves; "be courageous" = direct strength toward oneself